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I want to Be Prime Minister

Narendra Modi arrived in the national capital on 6 February 2013 looking every inch the muscular politician whose time had come. Delhi had seen many a conqueror aspire to its throne, and with news cameras tracking his every move, Modi gave the distinct impression he was ready to join the list. The sound of the Gujarat election triumph less than two months earlier was still resonating and Modi was keen to capitalize on the momentum. An *India Today* Mood of the Nation poll around Republic Day had suggested he was already the most preferred choice for prime minister—well ahead of the Congress troika of Rahul, Sonia and Manmohan—and he needed to capitalize on the enthusiasm.

The choice for his first public-speaking assignment was the Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC). The college was organizing a three-day business conclave and Modi was to deliver a memorial lecture as the grand finale. ‘We took a poll among the students as to who they wanted to listen to. Modi came out on top, ahead of Ratan Tata,’ says a member of SRCC’s students’ council. An invite was sent to Modi in mid-January, and his office responded in the affirmative in forty-eight hours. Interestingly, the students had also contacted half a dozen Union ministers from the Congress to come and speak at the conclave. All of them, including young leaders like Jyotiraditya Scindia and Sachin Pilot, refused. Some like Anand Sharma did not even reply.

Modi’s decision to speak at SRCC was well considered. The leading college for economics and commerce in the country, SRCC boasted seemingly ridiculous cut-offs of 98 per cent. It had built an enviable reputation for attracting the best and brightest students. A number of BJP